

CBSE CLASS 12 · POLITICAL SCIENCE · CHAPTER 1

THE END OF BIPOLARITY

PART ONE — THE COLD WAR WORLD (1945–1985)



USA & NATO



USSR & Warsaw Pact



A World Split in Two

A complete, visual guide to how the world split into two — and why that mattered.

What Is a Bipolar World?

For nearly 45 years after World War II, world politics worked like a two-player game. Every country leaned toward one of two **superpowers** — the **United States** or the **Soviet Union**. This arrangement of power is called **bipolarity** — and the decades-long rivalry between the two poles is the **Cold War**.

Definition (1-mark ready)

A world order in which power is concentrated in two dominant blocs, each led by a superpower with its own allies, ideology, and sphere of influence.



1945–91

Duration of the Cold War



2

Superpowers: USA & USSR



2

Rival alliances: NATO & Warsaw Pact

Timeline — From Revolution to Rivalry



Note: This is only half the story — the disintegration of the USSR (1991) and what followed is covered in Part 2.

The Cold War — Rivalry Without a Battlefield



A state of tension, hostility, and rivalry between the USA and USSR that never became a direct armed conflict between the two superpowers — but was fought through alliances, an arms build-up, propaganda, and proxy wars.

Why "Cold"?

Called "cold" because there was no direct "hot" war between the two superpowers themselves — although very real, very hot proxy wars were fought elsewhere, like Korea and Vietnam, where each side backed opposing forces.

NCERT Note: *Ordinary citizens on both sides lived under constant fear of nuclear war for decades.*

EXAMPLES OF PROXY TENSION

- **Korean War**
1950–53 — North (Soviet-backed) vs South (US-backed)
- **Vietnam War**
USSR/China-backed North vs US-backed South
- **Cuban Missile Crisis**
1962 — see next slide

Two Rival Blocs, Two Alliances



NATO

North Atlantic Treaty Organisation · 1949

- US-led military alliance of Western nations
- Built on collective defence — an attack on one is an attack on all
- Members: USA, UK, France, West Germany, Canada & more
- Purpose: deter Soviet expansion into Western Europe

VS



Warsaw Pact

Soviet-led military alliance · 1955

- Soviet-led military alliance of Eastern Europe
- Formed directly in response to NATO's creation
- Members: USSR, Poland, East Germany, Hungary & more
- Dissolved in 1991 along with the USSR itself

The Arms Race & the Cuban Missile Crisis



The Arms Race

Neither superpower wanted to fall behind militarily, so both kept building more — and deadlier — weapons, in a spiral with no real finish line.

- Extended beyond weapons into the Space Race (Sputnik, Moon landing)
- A show of technological & ideological superiority
- Extremely costly — diverted resources from social & economic development



Cuban Missile Crisis, 1962

The USSR secretly placed nuclear missiles in Cuba, dangerously close to the US mainland — pushing the world to the very brink of nuclear war.

- Resolved through negotiation, not conflict
- USSR withdrew missiles from Cuba
- US secretly withdrew missiles from Turkey in return
- Pushed both sides toward future arms-control agreements

PART TWO OF PART ONE



Inside the Soviet Union

The Soviet System · Its Economy · Its Politics · Its Reform

Features of the Soviet Economy



State Ownership

All industry and major property owned & controlled by the state, not private individuals.



Central Planning

The economy was guided by Five-Year Plans, not by market demand and supply.



Guaranteed Welfare

Full employment, and free or heavily subsidised healthcare, education & childcare.



Subsidised Essentials

Bread, milk & basic commodities kept artificially cheap through state subsidy.



Heavy Industry Focus

Massive emphasis on steel, machinery & defence — often at the cost of consumer goods.



Real Achievements

Rapid industrial growth, nuclear-power status, and leadership in space exploration.

Common Mistake: Don't call the Soviet economy "backward" — its real problem was long-term structural inefficiency, not a lack of achievement.

Political Structure of the USSR



One Party. Total Control.

The Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU) controlled every political, social and economic institution in the country — with no space for opposition parties or alternative political movements.

- **Centralised Decisions**

All major policy decisions were taken centrally by party leadership.

- **Privileged Bureaucracy**

A large bureaucracy controlled access to resources — breeding inefficiency & corruption.

- **Union of 15 Republics**

The USSR was a union of 15 Republics, with Russia by far the most dominant.

EXAM-READY ANSWER STRUCTURE

- One-party rule of the CPSU
- No political opposition allowed
- Centralised decision-making
- Russian Republic dominant among the 15

Use this exact order for a 2–3 mark answer.

1985 — The Rise of Gorbachev



Mikhail Gorbachev

Leader of the CPSU, March 1985

He became leader at a moment when the Soviet system was visibly falling behind the West — both economically and technologically.

He genuinely intended to save and strengthen socialism — not destroy it.

His answer: two landmark reforms →

Why Reform Was Urgently Needed

- **Economic stagnation**
Growth had slowed sharply; consumer goods were in chronic shortage.
- **Technological gap**
The USSR was falling behind the West, especially outside heavy industry.
- **Rigid bureaucracy**
Central planning had become inefficient, corrupt & unresponsive.
- **Costly arms race**
Decades of military spending strained the entire economy.

Perestroika vs Glasnost



Perestroika

"Restructuring" — economic reform

- Aimed at modernising the rigid, centrally planned economy
- Introduced market-oriented reforms
- Reduced defence spending; opened up to foreign investment
- Result: exposed deep economic weaknesses



Glasnost

"Openness" — political reform

- Allowed far greater freedom of expression
- Rolled back decades of press censorship
- Let citizens openly criticise the government
- Result: exposed deep political repression & fuelled dissent

Coming in Part 2: *How these very reforms triggered the disintegration of the USSR, the birth of Shock Therapy, and a new unipolar world.*